The Care Problems Checklist

What to write down, who to ask and what to keep open before the next family call.

Your father's care isn't working, and every phone call about it tries to cover ten problems at once. Before the family talks again, work through these. Check what you've done. Anything unchecked is a job for this week, not a verdict on anyone.

Write down

- [ ] The concerns people have raised about your father's care, each in the words the person used.
- [ ] One example beside each concern: what happened, and on which day. Where there isn't one, write “no example yet.”
- [ ] What each concern involves: care, communication, paperwork or workload.
- [ ] What has to happen for your father in a normal week, who is supposed to do each thing, and which of those aren't getting done.
- [ ] The decisions that are coming up, and the date each one is due.
- [ ] Where two people describe the same event differently, both accounts, side by side. Neither one is marked as the right one.

Ask

- [ ] Your father: what concerns him most about how things are going.
- [ ] Each person in the family: their main concern, one at a time.
- [ ] Your sister, who does most of the day-to-day: what has to change right away. [1]
- [ ] Your sister again: which tasks can't continue the way they are.
- [ ] For each concern the family can't settle itself, who you'd take it to: the doctor's office, the nurse, the pharmacist or your care consultant. Keep medication questions on their own line.

Keep open

- [ ] The few concerns to talk about on the next family call. The others stay written down for a later one. [1]
- [ ] For each concern you chose, one next action and the name of the person who will follow up. [1]
- [ ] An open-issues list for everything that isn't settled yet, with the date you'll look at it again. [1]

What this checklist doesn't do

It helps you write things down, ask the people who know, and keep track of what's still open. It doesn't say what a checked or unchecked box means, whose fault anything is, or what your father needs. That's for the people who assess him, and for the next step below.

Ready for the next step?

You've written down the concerns, asked the people who know, and put the rest on an open list. The care interview goes through your father's situation area by area, including the parts nobody has raised yet, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

Items marked 1 follow the Family Caregiver Alliance's guide to holding a family meeting, which suggests asking what support the primary caregiver needs, keeping a written summary of what each person agreed to, and planning on more than one meeting. The rest come from the Family Care Roadmap's own working list for this step.

1. Family Caregiver Alliance, Holding a Family Meeting